

Our former internet company (who was sadly not available when we moved to another area) used to offer a discount for loyal customers. They never advertised it, but whenever we were coming to the end of our promotion—usually twelve months—we would call them and ask to speak to someone in the customer loyalty department. We were always eligible for discounts and almost always paid \$20 or less per month after they applied the discounts.

—Lindsey, WA

4. BUY YOUR OWN MODEM

Internet providers often let you “rent” their modem for a set monthly fee, but this may or may not be the best deal depending on how long you will be using their service. A modem generally costs between \$60-\$100, so your internet company will make a killing after a specific time has passed.

Think about making this investment now, so you can save later, but be sure to consult with your provider before making any purchase. Most companies list exactly what kind of modem you need right on their website.

If you decide to switch companies based on a promotional rate, factor the cost of the modem in with your calculations as well. Like I mentioned before, DSL and cable modems are not interchangeable, and a different service may require a different modem.

5. EXPLORE ALTERNATIVE OPTIONS

Believe it or not, it is possible to get away without internet, and if the budget is tight, consider turning it off and jumping on a Wi-Fi connection whenever you need access. Local eating establishments, libraries, and even community parks have hotspots that are open to public use.

Some cell phone providers also let you use your phone as an internet hotspot. These plans are great for those who don't watch movies or download an insane amount of data. Always be sure to check with your phone provider, though, so you don't rack up extra fees and charges, and be